

TEST LAB

Glide Ways

BY ROGER COLLIER

Think of the **Core-Tex Reactive Training Device** as a skateboard in a giant dish. A 75-centimetre platform resting on three balls, it's designed to improve balance, mobility and fitness as it rotates in every direction. Created for exercises while standing, sitting or kneeling, it requires a slew of muscles to stay engaged. *US\$649, coretexfitness.com*



Stretching

Over Skype from his San Diego gym, Core-Tex inventor Anthony Carey ran me through several yoga poses. He had me twisting, lunging and downward dogging. I'm not a flexible guy—the last time I was in some of those positions, I was in the womb.

Core Strength

After warming up, we moved on to planks and other core-strengthening exercises. I typically do ab crunches, so I thought I would be up to the task. After these moves, my stomach, arms, shoulders and even legs could feel the burn. One exercise, a modified Spider-Man push-up, was the most challenging I've ever done. Think regular push-ups are tough? Try doing them while twisting your upper body on a jittery platform and moving a knee to meet an elbow.

Rehab

I'm not nursing an injury, but I asked Carey to show me how the Core-Tex could be used if I were, given that physical therapy accounts for a chunk of his business. He demonstrated gentle motions that could be used to strengthen ankles, knees and shoulders. The exercises, such as rotating my shoulder as far as I could while resting my forearm on the platform, challenged my range of motion but didn't hurt.

BEST FOR A tough but fun alternative to a tired fitness routine.

BANG FOR YOUR BUCK Not great...yet. It's a bit pricey to recommend for home use. Besides, attending classes is best because you'll need instruction initially. Some Canadian gyms have the equipment, but the company's 30-minute exercise program has yet to make its way north. Core-Tex does plan to offer a smaller, cheaper model by summer 2014.